

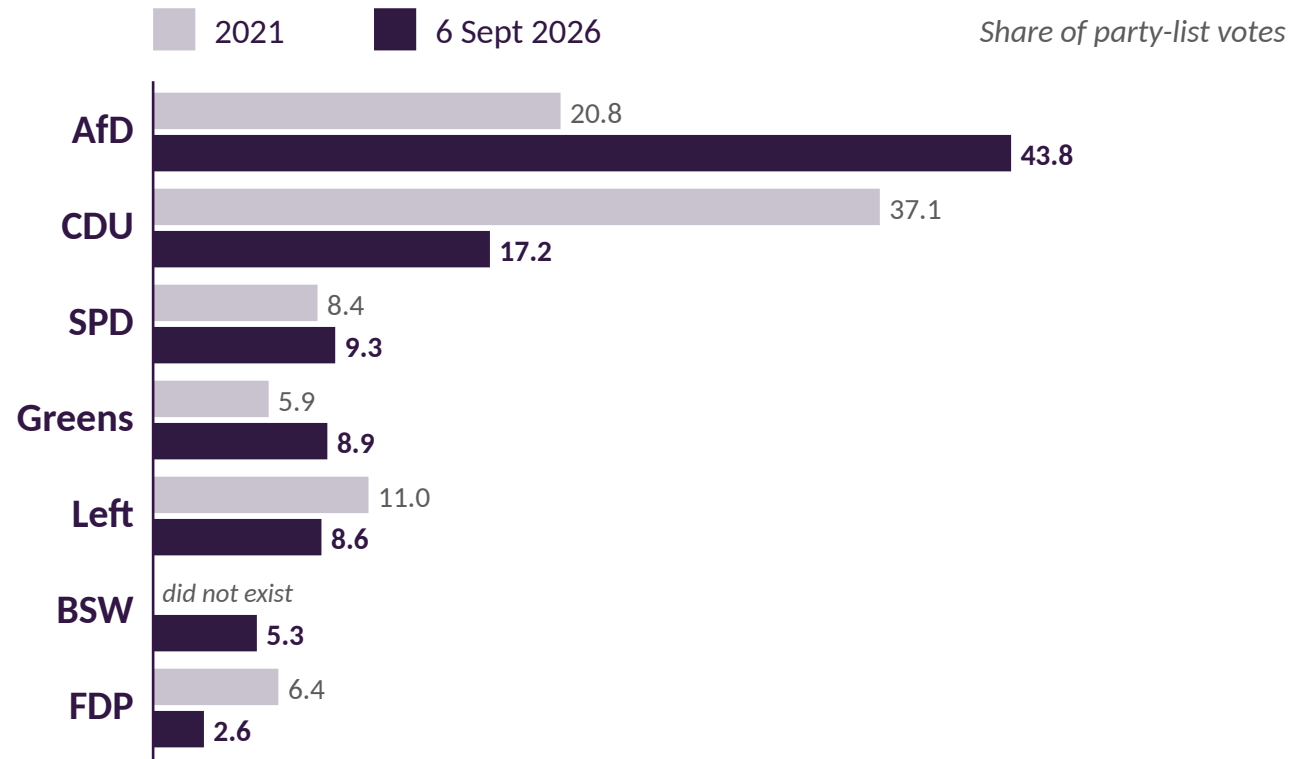
POSC 3710: European Politics

9/9/2026: A EUROPE OF NATIONS? NATIONS AND NATIONALISM

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Saxony-Anhalt (Germany) voted on Sunday



Details

- Turnout 77.8%, up from 60.3% in 2021. The highest since reunification
- The AfD won 38 of the 41 districts. In 2021 it won one district
- The CDU won 40 districts in 2021. This time it won none
- The three districts the AfD lost are in Magdeburg and Halle. The Left won them

Seats in the new Landtag: 83



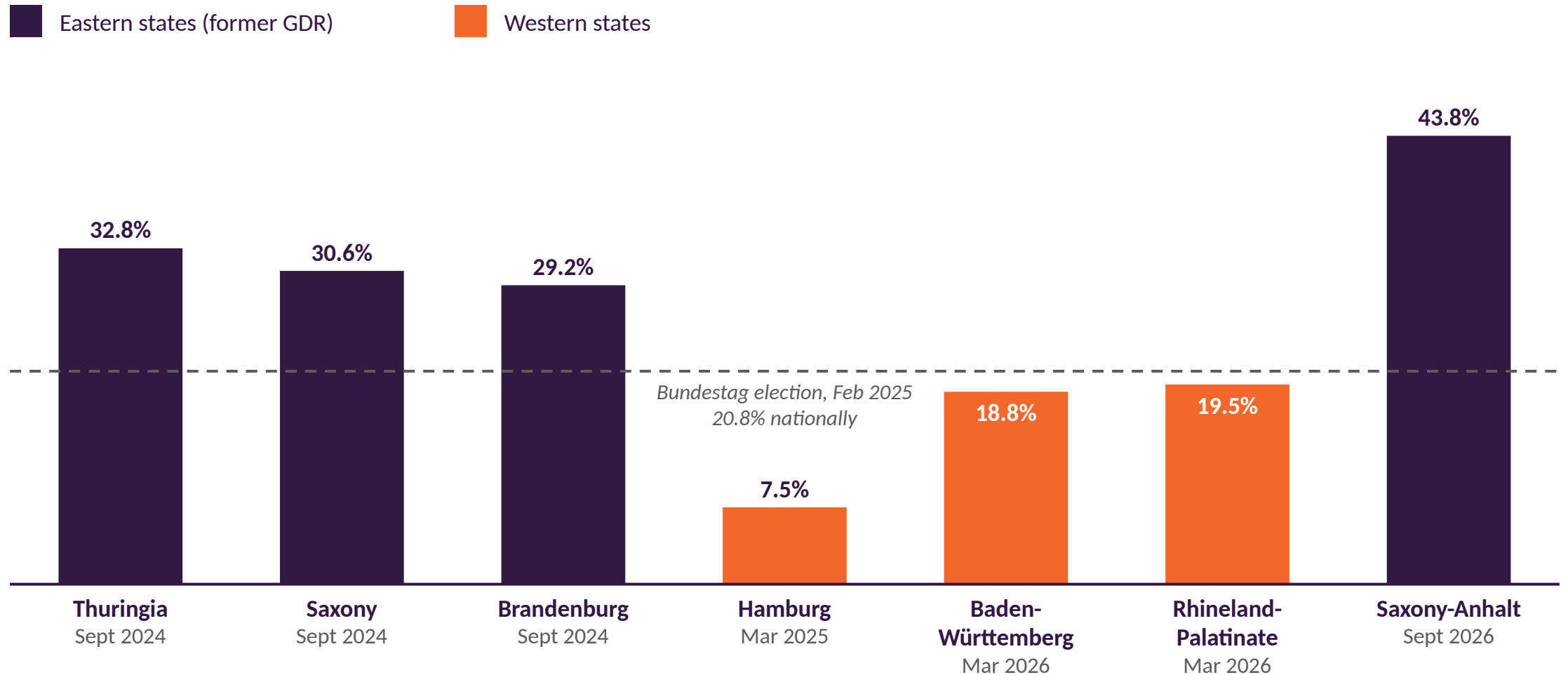
Majority: 42 seats. The AfD has 39 as does the non BSW opposition

Preliminary official result, Landeswahlleiterin Sachsen-Anhalt (7 Sept 2026); Landtag: 41 districts plus list seats, 5% threshold.

What Happened, What Next

- The AfD doubled its vote and won 38 of 41 districts. The CDU collapsed
- The state lists the AfD as right-wing extremist.
- Most parties will not consider working with AfD (BSW less clear on this)
- The CDU rules out working with AfD and Die Linke.
- Possible outcomes
 - BSW supports AfD
 - BSW + the rest of the parties form an anti-AfD government
 - New Elections

The AfD in every state election since 2024



Share of party-list votes, state election authorities; Saxony-Anhalt preliminary. Germany has been one state since 1990. Why does the east vote so differently?

Nations don't always have states

SCOTLAND

Contested Support

- Independence Referendum in 2014: No gets 55%
- Support for Independence seems to have increased after Brexit
- May 2026: SNP and Greens take 73 of 129 seats
 - The largest pro-independence majority ever elected
- Scottish Parliament voted 72–55 for anew referendum. Westminster said no

CATALONIA

The fragmentation problem

- Catalan parliament declares itself sovereign in 2013
 - Independence Referendum in 2014, 80% yes on 40% turnout. Not sanctioned by Spanish state
- In recent years, support for independence appears to have fallen
 - Polling shows it close, Catalan politics more fragmented
- Not the only movement for independence in Spai

CORSICA

Autonomy over Independence

- June 2026: the Assemblée votes 271–202 for autonomy
- Autonomy added to the constitution, inside the French Republic
 - Corsican recognised as a historic community
- Still needs the Senate and a Congress at Versailles

Why do these independence movements exist? What do they want?

Who counts?

- Italy, March 2026: automatic citizenship by descent ends
- Swiss Referendum tries to cap population
- France: naturalization now requires advanced French
- All trying to figure out who counts as a member of the national identity
 - And who is legally a member of the nation-state?

Where We Left Off

- Last week: how European states rebuilt themselves after 1945
 - Nation-States gave up sovereignty to facilitate it
- But we skipped a question...
 - What is a nation, and where did it come from?
- Today: What is national identity? Where does it come from?
- And: Why are there so many European nations without their own state

Opening Discussion

- What makes you a member of a nation?
 - Can you choose? What are the limits on this choice?
- Is there anything you would call an American tradition that is actually old?
- What would Scotland gain by becoming a state that it does not have now?
- Nations can exist without states: Can a state exist without a nation?





Charles V: Ruling Before Nations

- Ruled a collection of separate kingdoms at once
 - Crowned separately in each, on different terms
- Holy Roman Emperor, but also count, duke, king
 - His authority differed in every territory he held
- Language and culture were not the determinants



Free Cities and the Hanseatic League

- A trading network, not a territory
- From Belgium in the west to Russia in the east
- Cities taxed, raised armies, made war and treaties
- Members of empires and of the League at once
- Overlapping authority was normal, not a crisis

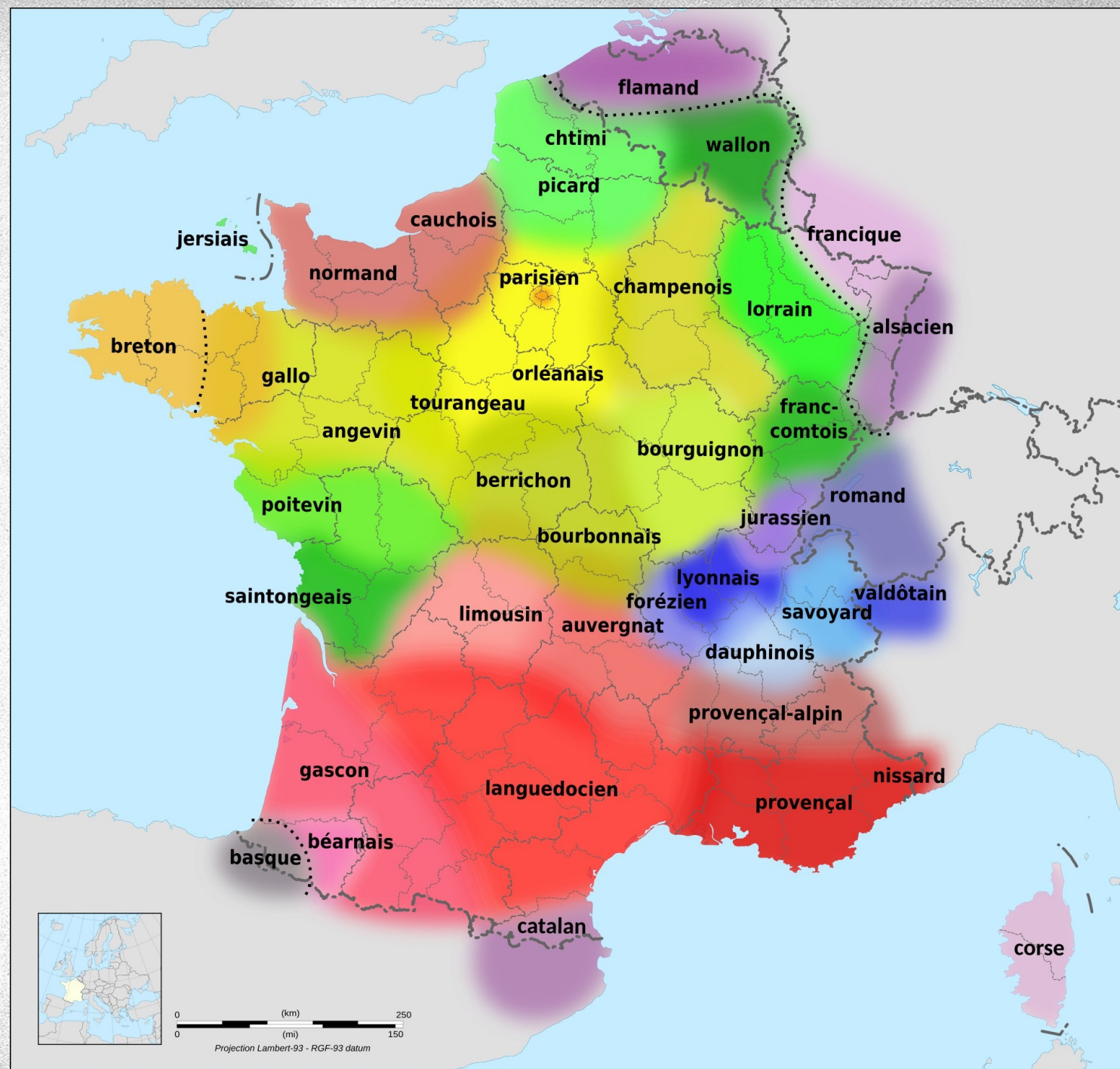


Popular Sovereignty, 1789

- Under the old regime, legitimacy came from God and dynastic inheritance
- Louis XIV: “L’état, c’est moi”
- In 1789 the French Third Estate declared itself a National Assembly
 - Claimed to represent the French nation, not the kingdom
- Today we assume legitimacy comes from the people. But who are they?

France: State to Nation

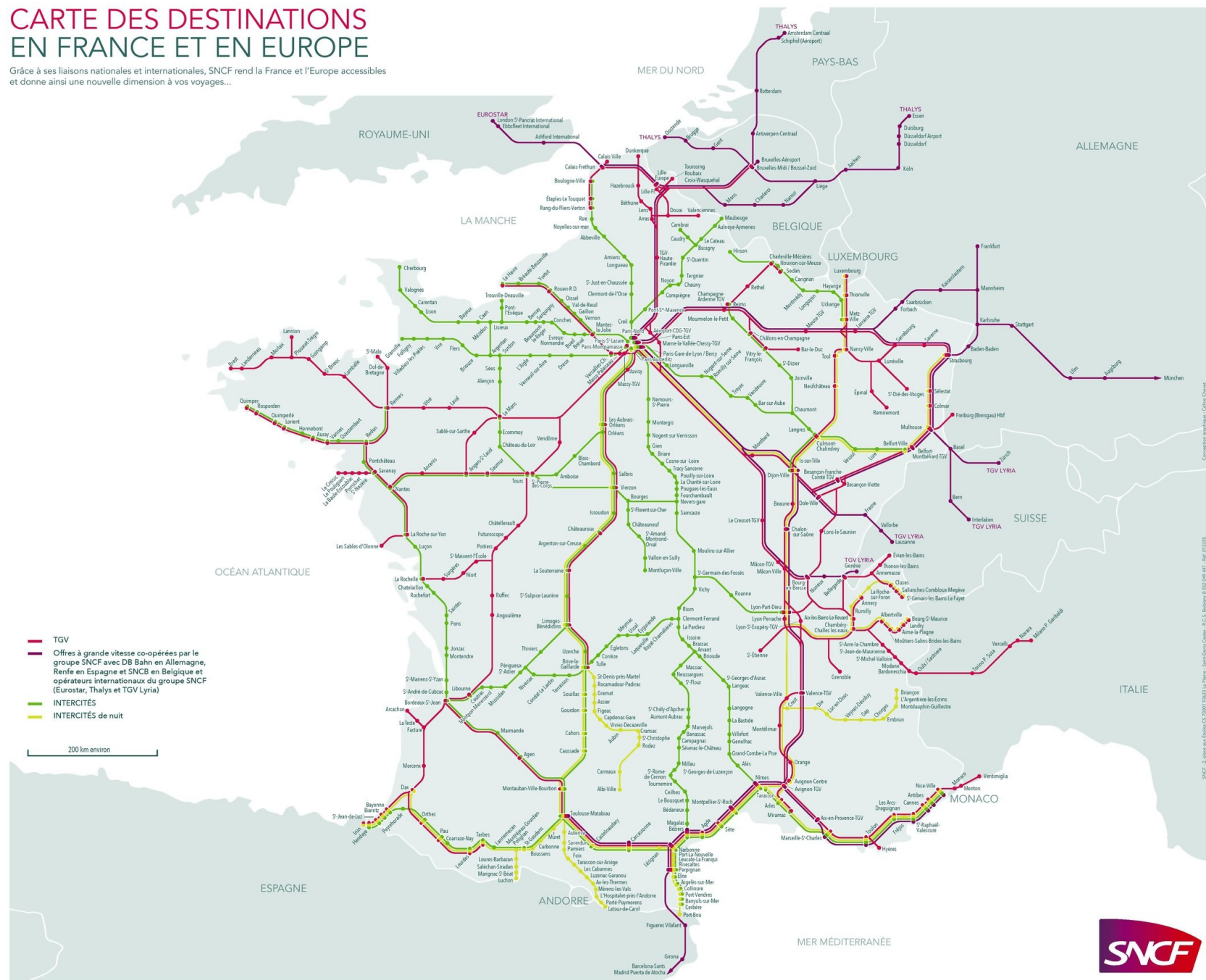
- Revolutionaries claimed to speak for “the French nation”
 - Most people inside France would not have thought themselves part of it
- So, the state set out to make (imagine) a nation
 - Schools, conscription, railways, a standardised language
- A state built with the purpose of constructing a nation





CARTE DES DESTINATIONS EN FRANCE ET EN EUROPE

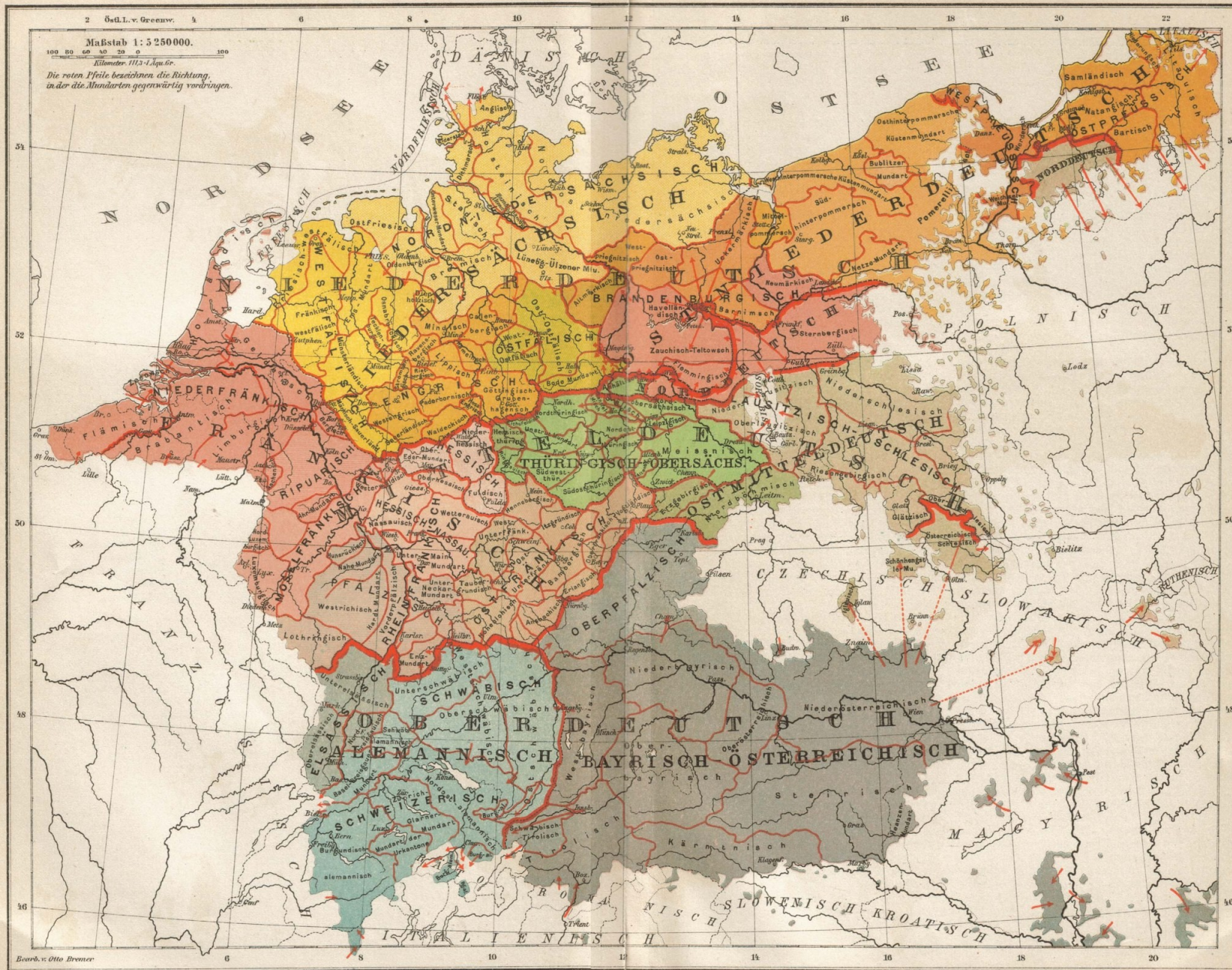
Grâce à ses liaisons nationales et internationales, SNCF rend la France et l'Europe accessibles et donne ainsi une nouvelle dimension à vos voyages...



Germany: Nation to State?

- The Holy Roman Empire was hundreds of states, loosely joined
 - Dissolved by Napoleon, leaving a power vacuum
- German intellectuals answered with cultural nationalism
- No single state existed to make Germans the way France made Frenchmen
 - But France provided a template for German intellectuals
- So the nation was imagined first, and the state built to house it

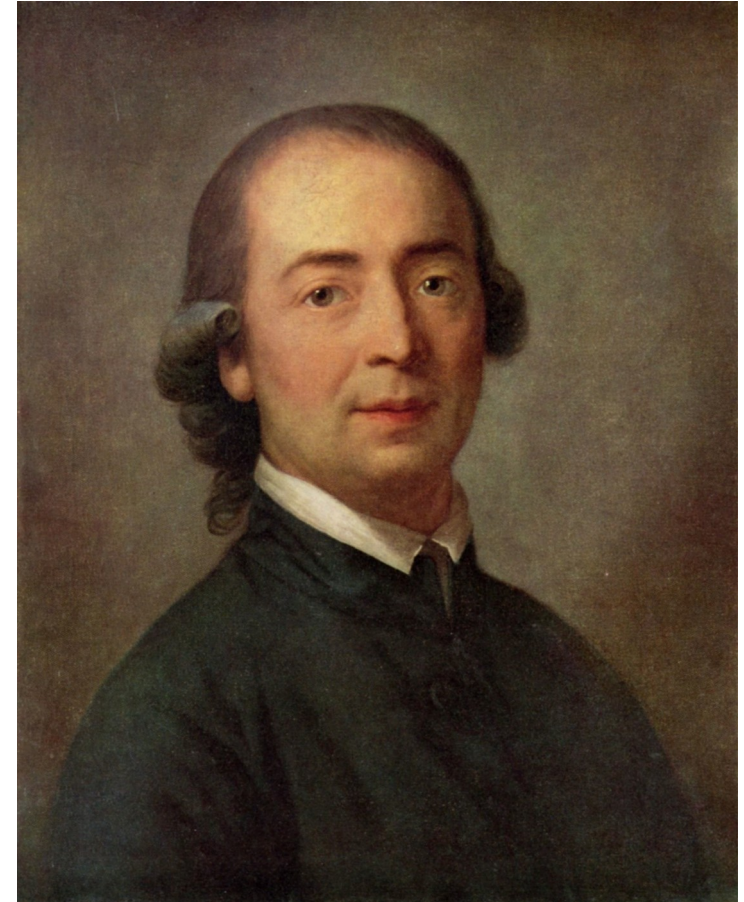
KARTE DER DEUTSCHEN MUNDARTEN.



Verf. v. Otto Bremer

Herder and the Volk

- Johann Gottfried Herder, 1744–1803
- The Volksgeist: a people's distinctive spirit
- Nations as natural, organic, and pre-political
- Made by language, folk tradition, shared heritage
- The opposite of the French approach





Competing Theories: Primordialists and Modernists

- Primordialists: nations are ancient, organic, "discovered"
- This is how nationalist movements describe themselves
- Serbia dates itself to Kosovo in 1389; Greece to Athens
- Modernists: nations are recent, and made
- Anderson and Gelner (and most historians/political scientists) are modernists
 - Most people are unknowingly primordialist

Gellner on Nationalism

- “Nationalism ... holds that the political and the national unit should be congruent”
- Where does it come from: Capitalism and Modernity
- Industry needs a mobile, literate, interchangeable workforce
 - Needs one standard culture, taught in schools
 - Only a state can run an education system that big
- So nationalism is an effect of modernity + industry

Anderson: Imagining Nations

- Sacred languages decline
 - Latin gives way to the vernacular (the languages that people speak)
- Printing Press + Mass media turns vernaculars into markets
- A print language creates a field of people who read together
 - Newspapers make strangers share a single day's events
- Identity forms around who you read with and about

Anderson's Key Insights

- The nation is “an imagined political community”
 - What does he mean by that?
- Limited: every nation has a boundary and an outside
- Sovereign: born in the age of revolution, against divine right of kings
- A community: “a deep, horizontal comradeship”

The Invention of Tradition

- Hobsbawm and Ranger (Optional): national traditions are often recent
- Trevor-Roper (optional) on Scotland: the kilt and the tartan
 - He dates the small kilt to 1727, and an Englishman
 - Clan tartans: a nineteenth-century commercial invention
 - My extended family would be very upset to hear about this!
- Invented tradition works by looking ancient

Theorists point to two different nationalisms

CIVIC

Membership by consent

- Built on citizenship and shared political values
- In principle open to anyone who accepts them
- The French revolutionary claim
 - American tradition as well
- Scotland's movement describes itself this way

ETHNIC

Membership by descent

- Built on ancestry, language, cultural inheritance
- You are born into it, or you are not
 - You can't *become* German
- Herder's claim of an organic nation
- This is how populist right movements often discuss the nation

Burt...France suppressed its regional languages for a century; Germany has had birthright citizenship since 2000.

Back to the Cases

- Scotland: a civic claim, and some autonomy already
- Catalonia: still a minority, and splitting on immigration
 - Basque independence movement has largely lost momentum
- Corsica: autonomy inside the Republic, not exit
- How do the theories we've read and discussed related to these national movements?

Discussion

- If nations are made, does that make national feeling less real?
- Gellner says industry needs one culture.
 - Do we have a shared global culture now? What are the implications?
- Should a state be allowed to decide who counts as a member of its national community?
- What would it take to make a new European nation today?

Where We Go Next

- 9/14: Christian Democracy and Social Democracy
 - The middle paths between Hayek's laissez-faire Liberal Capitalism and Marx's central planning/communism
- 9/16: the EU: a political order that is above the nation-state
- November: Immigration and the radical right
 - Policing national boundaries

The Federal Republic of Clemson

- Get into your party groups
- Introduce yourselves and start discussing party strategy
- Your manifesto is due Wednesday 9/30 (3 weeks)
- Does your party have a story about who the FRC is for?